

Postmodern Perspective on Indian Mythology: A Queer Reading of the Character of Shikhandi

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Abstract: *Mythology is the study of myths which have been preserved in written forms or have been surviving in society by the grace of oral tradition of disseminating moral values or religious beliefs. It has been playing a fundamental role in the formation and inculcation of social, cultural and moral values. Though, the mythical stories contain supernatural elements or exaggerated descriptions, one attribute that sets mythology apart from any other form of story is that it propagates philosophies of physical life and beyond that. The mythical folklores not only connect us to our cultural roots but at the same time it transgresses the boundary of time and helps us to understand the society that we tend to consider as the base of our traditions and customs. Myths bring together the ordinary and the extra ordinary and those tales have such a strong hold over our culture that we are bound to believe it. The different ideas and beliefs that are disseminated through these folklores are widely accepted by people; however, the societal norms that get reflected through these myths have become a subject matter of research in the recent time. The study of mythology allows us to look into the myths from diverse perspectives and make a comparative analysis of the past and present. Mythology, now-a-days has not remained in confinement within the boundaries of religion only; instead, it has entered into the area of research due to which mythology is now linked with society more often. In the context of the Hindu epic Mahabharata, which consists of many subplots, there are many issues that have relevance with the present society. The subject matter of queer is one such issue that is not given much significance; however, there are ample evidences through which queer theories can be studied in relation to the tales of the Mahabharata. This paper attempts to explore how the queerness is treated during the time of Mahabharata through the reading of the character of Shikhandi from a postmodernist point of view. To justify the aim of the paper, this paper takes the help of Devdutt Pattanaik's Shikhandi and Other Queer Tales They Don't Tell You.*

Keywords: Epic, folklore, Mythology, Queerness, postmodernist.

Michel Foucault is regarded as a forerunner philosopher, writer who immensely contributed in the field of queer discourse. His intellectual analysis on the interrelationships of knowledge, power and sexuality which is the ground in the formation of queer theory has challenged the established norms of the society. "A vital feature of Foucault's argument is that sexuality is not a natural feature or fact of human life but a constructed category of experience which has historical, social and cultural, rather than biological, origins." [4]. But Foucault does not say that there is no biological distinction in individuals. According to him, sexual preference is based on individual choice but the various institutions in the society are eventually responsible in the formation of rigid sexualities as masculine and feminine. He argues that different types of sexual preferences were still in the past but at that time their sexual preferences were repressed by social institutions. They could not come out with their real self. But in the modern period the people with queer identities, with their liberal mind, has come out in the public place by exposing their actual identity. Though they tend to expose their real self, the majority of the people refuse to accept it as natural identity and thereby they are categorized as 'Other'. Even in the 21st century Indian society, people have a conservative mindset towards the LGBTQ community. Even though the government is making efforts to change the traditional mindset of the people, the society is yet not free from the grip of prejudice. People still refuse to talk about these issues publicly. In Indian society, queerness is assumed as taboo and hence people with queer identities are deprived of equal social stature and freedom. The queer people are always looked down upon because they do not fall under the rigid

categories of male or female. Being rejected and humiliated by the mainstream society, they prefer to keep their identity in the closet and wish to camouflage their identity so that nobody can question their real self. In this respect, Sedgwick illustrates in the *Epistemology of the Closet* that “the closet is the defining structure for gay oppression in this country.”[3]. They cannot go against the societal norms created by the majority of people and thereby lead a life of compromised identity.

In contrary to the postmodern perspectives, the epic Mahabharata refers to a time where ‘Karma’ becomes the basis of queerness in the guise of a boon or curse [2]. There are ample evidences in mythology that the God and Goddess take various forms be it male to female or female to male in order to fulfill their responsibilities and promises. Therefore, the process of undergoing this change is celebrated in many of the myths where an individual who gets the boon of changing into a different self is considered superior to others as he or she possess this God-like power of changing into a different self. India’s forerunner mythologist Devdutt Pattanaik’s *Shikhandi and Other Queer Tales They Don’t Tell You* is a collection of queer stories from various Indian myths which have remained unexplored in the field of grand narratives. But this paper only focuses on the character of Shikhandi who belongs to the queer category according to the terminology of modern theorists. Although the power of slipping into another form or body was looked at as a divine thing, but the position of transgenders during that period is not much explored. In this respect, Devdutt Pattanaik illustrates that

No author has yet explored the relationship of Draupadi, the complete woman, and Dhristadhyumna, the complete man, with Shikhandi, who is neither a complete woman nor a complete man. Who will inherit Drupada’s throne? The eldest Shikhandi or the younger Dhristadhyumna? And what about Shikhandi’s relationship with his wife? How does it feel to know that your husband was a woman on the wedding night and then is a man in the following nights, sporting someone else’s genitalia? [2]

It is nowhere made clear whether Shikhandini had an innate inclination towards the male identity into which she was destined to fit in or it was because of her upbringing and her responsibility to fulfill the cause of her rebirth that she chose to become Shikhandi leaving behind her feminine self. But Foucault never made any comment whether queerness is innate inclination or construct of the society but his concentration was on the functions of queerness in society. Although her inner psyche has not been explored extensively in the book, it can be noted that she had some inborn queer qualities due to which she could undergo the process of metamorphosis. Shikhandini’s conflict of identity is hinted in the book through these lines, “For the girl thought like a man and felt like a man and had always been treated as a man. But that body of hers was certainly not a man’s.”[2]. While demonstrating the queer identity of Shikhandi, Esther Newton’s concept of ‘drag’ also seems relevant that projects the illusion of appearance and reality [1].

Furthermore, it cannot be denied that her father Drupada also plays a pivotal role in the transformation of her identity. Drupada, the king of Panchala had a strong intention of taking revenge on Drona because the Kuru princes had invaded Drupada’s kingdom as ordered by their guru Drona. As he did not have a son, Drupada knew that Shikhandini is left as the final option to overcome his disgrace. Moreover, Drupada had been promised by Lord Shiva that he would get a son. Therefore, Drupada brought up his daughter as his son imposing all the masculine qualities. The time period of Mahabharata was not free from the gender discrimination where patriarchy played a dominating role in the society. Women were not given equal position in the society. Acts of bravery, martyrdom, warfare was meant for men and therefore to be able to seek revenge from Drona, Shikhandini was trained to be a man by Drupada from her childhood days, meanwhile keeping her actual identity hidden from the people.

Although Drupada was aware of the fact that the queer identity of Shikhandi would not be recognized as normative in society yet he supported his daughter in the process of transformation into Shikhandi as his intention was to accomplish his revenge.

The Foucauldian concept reveals that queerness is not a product of modern society; it was still in the past. In the context of the time period of Mahabharata, Heterosexuality was the norm and anything beyond that was unimaginable. This gets revealed from the fact that Drupada did every possible effort to hide her feminine identity. Although he was a king, probably he too was under the influence of societal ideologies and perhaps, it is his fear of mass abhorrence that compelled him to make his daughter marry a girl to secure his daughter's masculine identity. It is revealed in the story that on the wedding night of Shikhandi, the bride was in the state of shock after finding out that her groom was a woman. She ran out of the wedding place because it was quite strange and unusual for her. Even the father of the bride, king Hiranyavarna took the incident as the act of humiliation and decided to take revenge on Drupada.

Hindu Mythology believes on the idea of 'Samsara' which implies the wheel of birth and death, and 'Karma' which refers to the impact of past actions on present circumstances and present actions on future circumstances [2]. Shikhandini's present identity is linked to her past life as she was reborn as Shikhandini only to take revenge on Bhishma. Again, revenge seeking was not considered as a woman's responsibility; so, it was important for her to get a masculine body. In the past, she was known as Amba who was abducted by Bhishma along with her two sisters to get married to his half-brother Vichitravirjya. Amba on the other hand, wanted to marry Shalva but unfortunately, Shalva did not accept her as his wife. Devastated at Shalva's rejection, she got furious on Bhishma and decided to take action on him who is responsible for her tragic situation. She tried all plans to fulfill her revenge motif but she could not succeed in her plans. At the end, she evoked Shiva who predicted that she would be the cause of Bhishma's death in her next life. But Shiva did not mention about her dualistic identity as a queer by means of which she would be able to fulfill her task. Shikhandini was unaware of her previous life until she received the garland of ever-fresh lotuses which was given by Kartikeya, god of war, as a weapon through which she could avenge Bhishma.

Although, the social position of queer people is not described extensively in the mythological narratives, it is seen that women and queer people were not allowed to involve in warfare affairs. In the *Mahabharata*, the character of Bhishma was blessed with a boon that he would only die on his own choice and no one else could kill him against his own will. It was because of Shikhandini's sacrifice of her feminine self and transformation into a masculine self through which she could camouflage her real identity and paved a way out to enter the battlefield of Kurukshetra. The death of Bhishma got possible only through the character of Shikhandi because Bhishma knew Shikhandi's queer identity and refused to fight in front of people with queer identity as it was the rule of Kurukshetra. The story of Shikhandi thus highlights a significant event of the historic battle that also helps to know about the queer people of the time of Mahabharata.

The birth of Shikhandini was a consequence of the events of her previous birth as Amba and it is through recalling her past life that she realized the pain she went through as Amba. It may be assumed that she had found an outlet for venting out her feminine emotions and directed all of Shikhandini's repressed anger towards accomplishing Amba's revenge which contributed towards the intensification of her determination to seek vengeance. She was destined to be the cause of Bhishma's death. It can also be said that it would have been impossible for Drupada to transform Shikhandini into Shikhandi if she did not have an innate inclination towards the masculine self. Just as in the modern times, where heterosexuality is the norm, it is depicted that during the time of Mahabharata as well, societal segregation based on gender identity and dominance of heteronormativity was prevalent. Although Drupada was a king; yet, he could not evade the societal normative. In order to concretize Shikhandi's masculine identity, he made Shikhandi to marry the daughter of Hiranyavarna.

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